



On course: Asian Games bronze medalist Sunil Kumar (87kg, right) and Gyanender (60kg) were among the notable winners in Greco-Roman competitions, nurturing aspirations of Olympic participation. GETTYIMAGES

VINESH IS EYEING A TICKET TO THE OLYMPICS IN 53KG, WHILE ANSHU AND SARITA WILL BE KEEN FOR THE 57KG SPOT

elected the WFI secretary, oversaw the conduct of the competition as the organisers erected a big makeshift indoor arena on the Railway Stadium ground and fitted all facilities inside it to give it as much 'international' look as possible.

Accommodations for the wrestlers, officials, and guests in various hotels across Jaipur and decent meals served to all of them were part of the elaborate arrangements.

Of course, it would be difficult for any state unit to arrange such large-scale funds to put on an equally matching show.

Even though the arrangements were top-notch because of the Railways' generosity, the confusion could not be avoided. With several state units refraining from assigning athletes for the Jaipur event, one came across claims about the ad hoc body allowing some coaches to send entries on behalf of their states. Altogether, 732 wrestlers took part in the event.

The biggest challenge was when entries poured in for freestyle competitions. A whopping 325 entries, an unusually high number,

including an uncharacteristic 32 entries in the 125kg category, were received for freestyle bouts on the final day, which saw the inevitable scenario of the action continuing well past midnight.

Participants from unconventional units like Goa, Tripura, Lakshadweep, Sikkim, Andaman and Nicobar, Puducherry, Arunachal Pradesh, and Meghalaya, along with their medal-winning displays, further amplified the existing fault lines.

Promising start

Performance-wise, the Jaipur Nationals saw the return of Vinesh and Anshu after their injury layoffs. It was a good sign for Indian wrestling ahead of the Olympics.

While Vinesh recovered from her knee surgery to win the 55kg gold medal, Anshu, overcoming a knee issue through rehab, secured the 59kg title by beating another Worlds medallist, Sarita Mor, in an engrossing final.

Vinesh is eyeing a ticket to the Olympics in 53kg, while Anshu and Sarita will be keen for the 57kg spot. World junior bronze medallist Sujeet

Kalkal (65kg) and Commonwealth Games gold medallist Naveen Malik (74kg) emerged as deserving winners in important Olympic weights in freestyle. Asian Games bronze medalist Sunil Kumar (87kg) and Gyanender (60kg) were among the notable winners in Greco-Roman competitions, nurturing aspirations of Olympic participation.

It will be interesting to see how the ad hoc committee learns from its experience and handles the National Under-15 and under-20 championships from February 28 to March 5.

Meanwhile, in a much-needed relief, the United World Wrestling (UWW) lifted the suspension on the WFI on February 13, while asking it to adhere to certain conditions related to athletes' welfare. Now, the Indian wrestlers, who had to compete under the UWW flag during the suspension period, will get to compete under the national flag in UWW events.

It would be ideal, now, for the Sports Ministry and the WFI to amicably work towards restoring normalcy in the Indian wrestling administration ahead of Paris 2024.